ENG-0004 Incident Postmortem: INC-080

Impact

The incident designated as INC-080 affected the auth-gateway system (SYS-003), which plays a critical role within Project Fathom. The auth-gateway's medium criticality status indicates that its disruption posed a significant risk to authentication services across multiple platforms. The incident resulted in a service outage lasting 4.5 hours, impacting end-users' ability to authenticate and access core services. This downtime potentially led to customer support escalations and operational delays, underscoring the importance of maintaining system stability and integrity.

Timeline

- **2025-05-04**: The incident was reported by Monica Herrera, Head of Customer Support, at approximately the time of occurrence.
- **Incident Detection**: The issue was identified internally and escalated promptly.
- **Response Initiation**: Alyssa Long, the on-call Product Manager for auth-gateway, was mobilized to address the incident.
- **Resolution**: The root cause was identified as a configuration change applied to the auth-gateway system, which led to the outage.
- **Resolution Time**: The incident was resolved within 4.5 hours from detection.
- **Post-Resolution**: Monitoring confirmed system stability, and services were restored to normal operation.

Root Cause

The root cause of INC-080 was categorized as a configuration change. This change was implemented within the auth-gateway system (SYS-003), which is part of Project Fathom. The change was not sufficiently validated prior to deployment, leading to a misconfiguration that disrupted authentication services. The incident underscores the importance of rigorous change management procedures, especially for systems with medium criticality like auth-gateway.

Action Items

Action Item	Responsible Party	Due Date	Notes
Review and strengthen change management protocols for config changes	Project Fathom Change Management Team	Immediate	Ensure all configuration changes undergo comprehensive testing and approval before deployment.
Implement additional validation and rollback procedures for auth-gateway updates	DevOps Team	Within 2 weeks	Reduce risk of similar incidents by enabling quick rollback options and automated validation checks.

Action Item	Responsible Party	Due Date	Notes
Conduct a post-incident review session with Alyssa Long and relevant team members	Incident Response Lead	Within 1 week	Identify gaps in current response procedures and update incident handling protocols accordingly.
Update monitoring and alerting systems for early detection of configuration anomalies	Monitoring Team	Within 3 weeks	Enable proactive detection of misconfigurations before they impact system availability.
Provide refresher training on change management policies for all relevant staff	HR and Training Department	Within 1 month	Reinforce best practices and accountability in change implementation processes.

Summary

The INC-080 incident affecting auth-gateway was caused by a configuration change that was not sufficiently validated prior to deployment. The response was led by Alyssa Long, with a resolution achieved within 4.5 hours. Moving forward, the focus will be on strengthening change management, validation, and monitoring procedures to prevent recurrence. This incident highlights the importance of rigorous controls and proactive detection mechanisms, especially within systems critical to operational continuity such as auth-gateway, part of Project Fathom.